

KEYNOTE SPEAKER Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan at the Conclave

HOW NEP 2020 WILL CHANGE THE INDIAN EDUCATION SYSTEM

DHARMENDRA PRADHAN

Union Minister of Education, Skill Development and Entrepreneurship

"What is our challenge? In the student age group (3–23), there are 520 million people, of which 300 million are in schools (of all kinds). This means some 200 million are out of the network"

"China and Japan don't depend on English for R&D, high-end jobs or as a medium of communication. If we have to grow, we have to think about our local languages"

"The Government of India crossed Rs 1 lakh crore for the first time in this year's budget for education. The state governments and private institutions are spending. Philanthropic investment is coming also"

"We don't want to have any restrictive regulation. Innovators are creative people, let them do their innovation. Yes, we expect some adherence to moral guidelines. Edtech should not be exploitative"

"We are prepared with the document for the Higher Education Commission Bill. Very soon, we will take it to the Cabinet. We should be able to table it in the next session of Parliament"

major challenges faced by his ministry—for one, the huge gap between supply and demand. "Our [total student] population is about 523 million," he said. "If I put together [all enrolled students], including those in anganwadis, schools, higher education institutions and those in skill education, the number will be about 320 million. That means another 200 million are outside the education net." He went on to address an underlying issue in education—the question of language. "In India, we believe that employability is a major challenge," he said. "For employability, you have to learn English. But if I analyse major developed economies, three or four countries are not doing their R&D, their high-end jobs in English. There is China. There is Japan. They don't depend on English as a medium of communication. Yes, English is a global language, the language of business, of trade. But if I analyse major languages across the globe, two of the top 10 are from India.... If we have to grow, we have to think about local languages."

The minister's remarks were followed by a Q&A exchange with India Today Group Editorial Director (Publishing) Raj Chengappa. On budgetary support for education—still just about three per cent of GDP—the minister agreed that meeting India's academic targets would require massive funding but highlighted the investments, saying, "The government has invested more than Rs 1 lakh crore to implement the NEP. The state governments are also spending. Private institutions are also spending. Philanthropic investment is coming." Pradhan said his ministry was making progress on a Higher Education Commission, saying, "We are prepared with the document for the Higher Education Commission Bill. Very soon, we will be taking it to the Cabinet. We should be able to table the bill in the next session of Parliament." When asked about regulations for the edutech sector, he walked the line between being enthusiastic and arguing for a rules-based system: "We don't want to have restrictive regulations. Innovators are creative people—let them innovate. But we expect some adherence to moral guidelines. Edutech should not be exploitative." ■